

THE MORNING KICKOFF



🏆 FIFA World Cup 26 — United States · Canada · Mexico · Rest day — quarter-finals from Thursday

Messi leads the Golden Boot outright on 8 goals

The last eight are set — quarter-finals start Thursday

Switzerland reach a first quarter-final since 1954

⚡ CHAMPIONS DO CHAMPION THINGS

MESSI'S ELEVEN-MINUTE MIRACLE

Two goals down with eleven minutes left, a penalty already missed — and then Argentina scored three times to break Egypt's hearts, Messi taking the Golden Boot lead in the middle of it. In Vancouver, Switzerland and Colombia needed penalties after 120 goalless minutes, and Gregor Kobel sent the Swiss into a first quarter-final in 72 years.

ALSO THIS MORNING

- ★ Crystal Ball, day two: Argentina called correctly (if far less comfortably than predicted); Colombia didn't land — though the verdict did warn of penalties in Vancouver.
- 🏆 Egypt goalkeeper Mostafa Shoubir saved a Messi penalty and led 2–0 with 11 minutes left — the fairy tale died very, very hard.
- 📅 No football today. The quarter-finals begin Thursday: France–Morocco in Boston, then one tie a day through Sunday.

INSIDE TODAY'S EDITION

- P.2** Argentina 3–2 Egypt — the comeback of the tournament, minute by minute
- P.3** Switzerland 0–0 Colombia (4–3 pens) — Kobel's wall and a 72-year wait ended
- P.4** The quarter-final card: France–Morocco and Spain–Belgium up first
- P.5** Golden Boot: Messi finally alone at the top — Mbappé and Haaland one behind
- P.6** The completed bracket and your week to the final



Lionel Messi — a missed penalty, an assist, and his 8th goal of the tournament, all in one night

TONIGHT (CENTRAL EUROPE)

France – Morocco **Thu 22:00**

Spain – Belgium **Fri 18:00**

FULL PREVIEWS PAGE 4 →

⚡ COMEBACK



Argentina

3 – 2

Egypt 

FULL TIME

⚽ Romero 79' · from a Messi cross

⚽ Messi 83' · his 8th

⚽ Enzo Fernández 90'+2

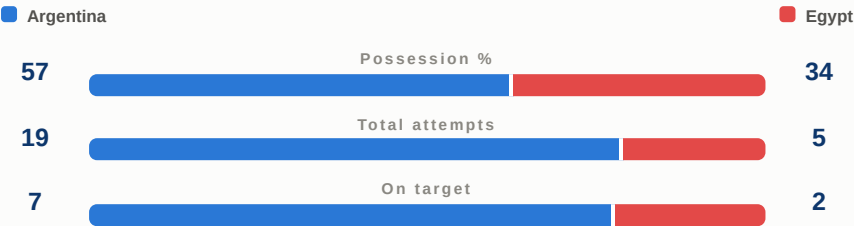
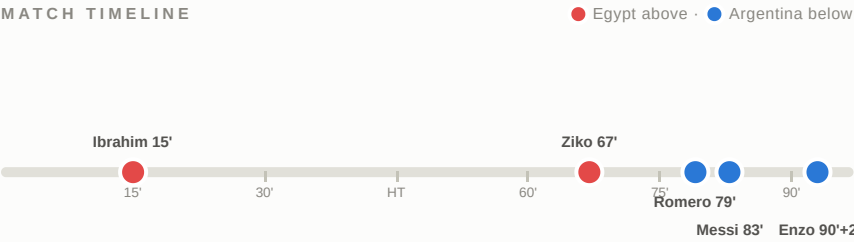
⚽ Ibrahim 15' · header

⚽ Ziko 67'

Mercedes-Benz Stadium, Atlanta

Egypt did everything but finish the job. Yasser Ibrahim's 15th-minute header from a corner, a Messi penalty pushed away by Mostafa Shoubir minutes later, and a second from Mostafa Ziko on 67 — the champions were two down, out of ideas, and out of time. Atlanta braced for the shock of the tournament.

Then Argentina remembered who they are. Cristian Romero headed in Messi's cross on 79, Messi swept in the equaliser on 83 — his eighth, and the Golden Boot lead — and Enzo Fernández completed the turnaround in stoppage time. Nineteen attempts to five tells you the pressure never stopped; champions simply refuse to lose until the maths says they must.





★ STAR OF THE MATCH

Lionel Messi

A saved penalty would have broken most players. Instead, at 39: the cross for Romero, the equaliser for the Golden Boot lead, and one more quarter-final. His tournament now runs through Switzerland on Sunday.



Enzo Fernández

The stoppage-time winner that turned a great escape into a statement. Argentina's engine room delivered when the legs of others had gone.

🧤 Goalkeeper Mostafa Shoubir saved Messi's first-half penalty — and Egypt led 2–0 until the 79th minute

📊 Messi's 83rd-minute strike was his 8th of the tournament — the outright Golden Boot lead

⚡ Argentina scored three times in 13 minutes after going 25 games' worth of knockout pedigree into the red

➔ **WHAT IT MEANS** Argentina meet Switzerland in Sunday's Kansas City quarter-final (02:00 +1). Egypt exit their finest World Cup one hurdle short of history.

⚡ SHOOTOUT

📍 BC Place, Vancouver



Switzerland

0 – 0

FULL TIME

Colombia



⚽ **Vargas** pens · winning kick

⚽ **Hernández** pens · saved by Kobel

Exactly the match the market predicted: 120 minutes, no goals, and the finest of margins. Colombia created what chances there were — Lucumí rattled the crossbar and Campaz fired over in extra time, their 1.03 xG dwarfing Switzerland's 0.35 — but the Swiss block never cracked, and the night went where it always felt destined to go.

In the shootout, Gregor Kobel dived to keep out Carlos Hernández's kick, and even Manuel Akanji's miss couldn't swing it back: Ruben Vargas swept in the winner for 4–3. Switzerland reach the last eight of a World Cup for the first time since 1954, and Colombia go home having lost, in the truest sense, to nobody.



★ STAR OF THE MATCH

Gregor Kobel

A clean sheet through 120 minutes behind a creaking block, then the decisive save in the shootout. Switzerland's 72-year wait ended on his gloves.



Ruben Vargas

The man for the moment that mattered most — the winning penalty, buried without a flicker of doubt.

⚡ Colombia's xG of 1.03 to 0.35 tells the story: Lucumí hit the crossbar and Campaz blazed over in extra time

🧤 Kobel saved Hernández's kick in the shootout; Akanji's own miss didn't matter in the end

🏆 Switzerland are in a World Cup quarter-final for the first time since 1954 — a 72-year wait

➔ **WHAT IT MEANS** Switzerland meet Argentina in Sunday's Kansas City quarter-final. The reward for 120 minutes of discipline: the champions of the world.

QF1 • THURSDAY • BOSTON



France

VS

Morocco



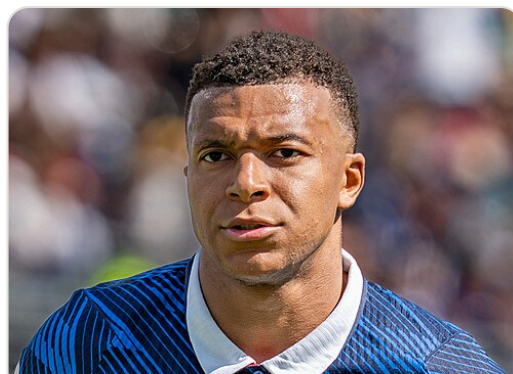
🕒 Thu 22:00

Kick-off 4:00 PM ET at the stadium

📍 Gillette Stadium, Boston

A rematch of the 2022 semi-final, and the tie of the round. France have cruised on Mbappé's seven goals and Dembélé's wing play; Morocco arrive as the best defensive side of the knockouts bar Spain, fresh from dismantling Canada 3–0. In 2022 they ran out of miracles against exactly this opponent — Thursday tells us if this squad is different.

- 👁 Mbappé, one behind Messi, against the defence that shut out Canada
- 👁 Winner faces Spain or Belgium in Tuesday's Dallas semi-final



KEY MAN • FRANCE

Kylian Mbappé

Seven goals, two assists, and the memory of 2022 — the last time Morocco stood between France and a semi-final, he was on the winning side.

QF2 • FRIDAY • LOS ANGELES



Spain

VS

Belgium



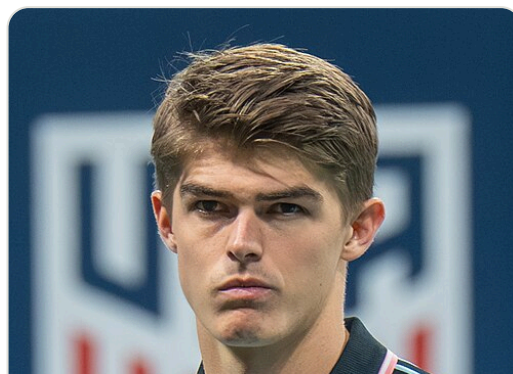
🕒 Fri 18:00

Kick-off 9:00 AM PT at the stadium

📍 SoFi Stadium, Los Angeles

The tournament's meanest defence against its suddenly hottest attack. Spain have not conceded a single goal in five games; Belgium just put four past the hosts in their sharpest display in years. Something gives on Friday — and the winner will fancy themselves in the semi-final.

- 👁 Spain's five straight clean sheets against De Ketelaere's new-found ruthlessness
- 👁 Oyarzabal (4 goals) quietly stalking the Golden Boot podium



KEY MAN • BELGIUM

Charles De Ketelaere

Two goals against the USA announced him as Belgium's new tournament talisman. Now the hardest assignment in football: finding a way past a Spain defence that hasn't blinked in five games.

⚽ HOW THE LAST EIGHT WAS SETTLED

The other round-of-16 results

🇵🇹 Portugal 0 – 1 Spain 🇪🇸

Mon

🇺🇸 United States 1 – 4 Belgium 🇧🇪

Mon

🇧🇷 Brazil 1 – 2 Norway 🇳🇴

Sun

🇲🇽 Mexico 2 – 3 England 🇬🇧

Sun

TOMORROW: QF1 — FRANCE–MOROCCO IN BOSTON, 22:00



8

Lionel Messi

The equaliser against Egypt put him clear at the top, at 39



7

Kylian Mbappé

Plays Morocco Thursday — 2 assists keep him ahead of Haaland



7

Erling Haaland

Waits for England on Saturday night in Miami



Tie-break: assists, then minutes played. Messi now leads outright; Mbappé holds 2nd on assists.

⚡ NUMBERS OF THE DAY

8

Messi's tournament goals — the outright Golden Boot lead, at 39 years old

11'

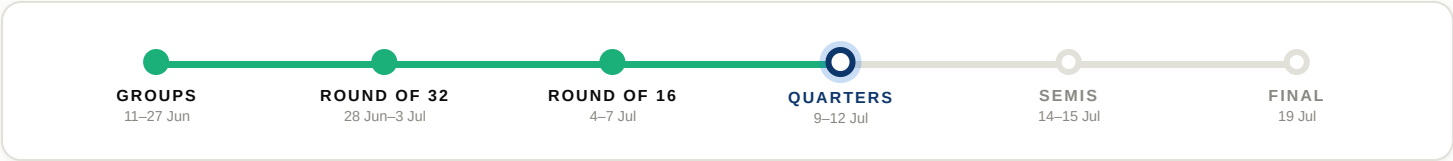
Minutes left when Argentina, 2–0 down, began the comeback of the tournament

1954

The last time Switzerland reached a World Cup quarter-final — until last night

1.03

Colombia's xG in Vancouver against 0.35 — and still they went home



KNOCKOUT BRACKET

Quarter-finals 9–12 July · Semi-finals 14–15 July

QUARTER-FINALS

QF1 · Thu 9 July · 22:00 · Boston

France

Morocco

QF2 · Fri 10 July · 18:00 · Los Angeles

Spain

Belgium

QF3 · Sat 11 July · 23:00 · Miami

Norway

England

QF4 · Sun 12 July · 02:00 (+1) · Kansas City

Argentina

Switzerland

SEMI-FINALS

Tue 14 July · Dallas

Winners QF1 vs QF2

Wed 15 July · Atlanta

Winners QF3 vs QF4

THE FINAL

Sunday 19 July

MetLife Stadium, New York / New Jersey

YOUR WEEK IN FOOTBALL

Monday 6 — Sunday 12 July

WED
8 Jul

Rest day — catch your breath

THU
9 Jul

QF1 France–Morocco · 22:00

FRI
10 Jul

QF2 Spain–Belgium · 18:00

SAT
11 Jul

QF3 Norway–England · 23:00

SUN
12 Jul

QF4 Argentina–Switzerland · 02:00 (+1)

MON
13 Jul

Rest day — semi-finals loom

TUE
14 Jul

Semi-final 1 in Dallas

See you tomorrow morning.

Next edition: the quarter-finals are ON — France–Morocco report, the full Spain–Belgium preview, and the Crystal Ball returns with live market prices.